creation of a few national universities that would keep the tradition of the university alive till experience makes men re-examine the wisdom of what they have done'. He identified five likely carriers of this noble ideal—the three 'premier universities' in Bombay, Calcutta and Madras, plus two new universities to be sited in the north and the south respectively. These national universities, he felt, 'could ensure the continuity and development of all-India cultural life so essential in the context of regionalization'. They would 'provide the nation with a window to the world, and also a yard-stick by which the work of the regional universities could be evaluated'.

In the 1970s, the central government did establish one national university in the north (the Jawaharlal Nehru University) and another in the south (the University of Hyderabad). These two institutions, along with the far older Delhi University, have (as Shah hoped) helped in keeping some kind of all-India intellectual discourse alive. On the other hand, the three founding universities of Bombay, Calcutta and Madras have become more parochial rather than national in their orientation.

In his contribution to that symposium in 1962, the economist B.R. Shenoy focused on the declining quality of university and college teachers. This, he felt, was due to three reasons: abysmally low salaries, which meant that alternative professions were more attractive; the reproduction in the university of bureaucratic red-tapism, which meant that administrators were more important and more powerful than professors; and regionalism, which 'on the one hand, repels from the academic profession men from outside the region and, on the other, adds to the pressure for migration out of the profession'. Shenoy also called for the creation of national universities which would be 'wholly autonomous … free from interference by the government or any political organization'.

This writer is also not the first to sing the praises of university pluralism. In a talk broadcast over the Delhi station of All India Radio on 17th March 1940, Sir Maurice Gwyer outlined what he saw as the future of the university he was then heading. He called, first of all, for 'the transference of all the constituent colleges of the [Delhi] University to a